

Changes in the services schedule for St. Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney Texas

New Diocesan directives

March 14/27, the 4th week of Great Lent, 2020

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27.pdf http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27.doc

In Russian: http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27-r.pdf http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27-r.doc

Dear Faithful in Christ,

Of course, we have news for you, and that news is drastically different than the previous day, just as the news about the Coronavirus (COVID-19) and the impact of that news on our lives changes drastically from day to day. We are Orthodox Christians, and we can do nothing that bears fruit without obedience to our bishop. Archbishop Peter has written a recent letter with directives, and we will follow them. He has also written a pastoral letter to his priests, and we have been very edified by that letter and have full confidence in his pastoral judgment and his sense of Christian obedience and restraint.

Therefore, it is with faith and in obedience to our Bishop that we write to you with these latest changes. Out of concern for both your spiritual and physical health, and in compliance with the concerted effort by the civil authorities to stop the spread of the coronavirus from person to person, Archbishop Peter has decided that **public services will no longer be held in the diocese until further notice. We will continue to serve all of the Divine Services, but with only the smallest number of clergy and assistants possible.**

Fr Nicholas and I discussed this at length, and we have decided, with Vladyka's blessing, to make some stricter changes (he has told all of his priests that we can make stricter directives). The City of McKinney has banned any gatherings for almost any reason. It is now illegal for us to have you come to the church for communion. This will be a bitter pill for many of you, but we must be willing to taste bitter things, or else we will never know the sweetness of Christ.

My wife is a nurse. She is therefore a likely vector for the disease, which means I am a likely vector for the disease. Therefore, Fr Nicholas and I will not physically be in each other's presence for the foreseeable future. He will serve an entire week, and then I will serve. He will serve only with his family, and I will serve only with Marina, and possibly Tim and Christina and their family since I take care of their children when they are working, and Christina is also a nurse and a possible vector.

We are making these changes because of love. I want to stress to you very firmly that *there is no possibility that you will get the disease from taking the Holy Mysteries or kissing the chalice.* However, of course, Christians are not immune to the disease when it is aerosolized, or lying on some surface. We have a responsibility to protect our

brother and sister, as it is possible we can be carriers even if we don't suffer from the disease. Perhaps some of you might think that we are being extreme and alarmist, but Fr Nicholas and I will live with that, because our motives are not because of fear but because of love. We are responsible for all of our brothers and sisters, the ones who believe and the ones you do not believe. We are obeying the civil authorities as a choice, and not because of fear or timidity. We recently read some medical information from an ER doctor about treating the disease, and Marina, and Fr Nicholas and I are quite sure that the course we are taking is the correct one.

We **were** planning on making Communion available after Sunday liturgy, in such a way that no one would come into contact with one another. You would all come in your cars, and stay in them. One at the time, those in a single car would come to the front of the church where they would be communed outside. This is very safe, and I wish we could do it but we would be in violation of the city order. There may come a time when we reevaluate, but this is not the time. The world is watching us, and we not only must do nothing to offend the little ones, but we also must be prudent.

Perhaps we will be able to institute this policy in the coming weeks, but right now, we are asking that no one come the church. We are begging you, however, that on Saturday and Sunday you observe the day with prayer. We are Christians! We must pray. In a time of pestilence, we must increase our prayer, both for ourselves and for those around us, that is all of those in the society in which we live, whom we love. I plan to serve at the church every single day, and Fr Nicholas will serve often.

Our Bishop has urged us to remain calm. Huge numbers of people around us are panicking. We will continue to serve the Liturgy and to commemorate all of you and your loved ones. The particles taken out in your names will be added to the chalice at the appropriate time, as always. Please feel free to send us updated commemoration lists electronically, and we will be sure to read them at each Liturgy. The priest who is not "on duty" at the church remains on duty! We will plan to serve the liturgy at home, so you will be commemorated twice.

None of us is being deprived of any grace, and actually, this crisis is an opportunity for us to gain grace. We are resolute, and we are actually excited, because this crisis is an opportunity for all of us to become more Christian. You must plan, and what is more, succeed in your plan to pray more intensely and often. Without prayer, truly the world would end.

We are working on establishing online meetings which we hope to have on a regular basis.

We are not separated! Prayer binds us. I have this experience every day, since I pray for many people that pray for my son +Daniel, and many people in prison whom I see more and more irregularly now. We pray for each one of you every day, and even if we don't see you a given week, we are connected to you. It is critical that you pray for one another, and for the world.

I'm asking you to pray at least the prayers in the Moleben against pestilence, every day. I recommend strongly that you get on your knees when you pray these prayers. I'm working on a Paraklesis (Supplicatory service,

like a Moleben) to St Nikephorus the Leper, and you will have access to that soon. I also recommend that you pray the Akathist of the Mother of God or her Paraklesis, and any other prayers that you find beneficial and which resonate in your soul.

Use this time to increase your prayer! If we are more awake, and not sleepy in our sins, as a result of our increased prayer and concern for our brother and sister, God will give us grace beyond anything we can imagine. If you do this, you will receive more grace than a thousand days of the Holy Mysteries.

We are getting high-speed Internet installed at the church on Monday. We will be able to live stream services from that point on, and we plan, God willing, to serve every day in the church.

On Sunday, please continue to say the Typica service and read the Gospel and Epistle for the day. If you watch our live stream or any other, please do so as a participant. Stand, cross yourself, pray and even sing along.

We will look for ways to increase our internet outreach to all of you, to strengthen and encourage you during this time. We are open to suggestions from you. We could do live question-and-answer sessions and many other things. We will rely on your collective intelligence to help us decide what to do. Look for more information soon!

With love in Christ,

Priest Seraphim and Priest Nicholas

Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net 972 658-5433

Priest Nicholas Park frnicholas@orthodox.net 972 839-2439

Church Web Page: <http://www.orthodox.net> Church Facebook Page: <https://www.facebook.com/orthodoxnet/>

EMAIL List: <http://groups.google.com/group/saint-nicholas-orthodox-church>

Typica: <http://www.orthodox.net/services/typica-4th-sunday-of-great-lent-john-climacus-2020-03-29-ns.html> (Complete file for the 4th Sunday of Great Lent, links to doc and pdf file are in this document)

<https://fatherjohn.blogspot.com/2020/03/doing-typika-at-home.html>

Полный чин Обедницы для мирян можно скачать здесь: https://sinod.ruschurchabroad.org/bib_obednitsa-dlia-mirian.pdf

A Moleben sung in time of devastating epidemic and death-bearing pestilence. Abbreviated, for use when no priest is present. (Web page has links to pdf and Word Doc versions) : <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence-reader.html>

Full Service: A Moleben sung in time of devastating epidemic and death-bearing pestilence. (Web page has links to pdf and Word Doc versions): <http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence.html>

Prayers to St Nikephoros: <http://www.orthodox.net/articles/prayer-to-nikephoros-the-leper-during-the-coronavirus-pandemic.html> (Web page has links to pdf and Word Doc versions)

Akathist to our Sweetest Lord Jesus Christ : <http://stjonah.org/akathist-to-our-sweetest-lord-jesus-christ>

Akathist to the Most Holy Theotokos: http://www.fatheralexander.org/booklets/english/m_akathist_e.htm

Supplicatory Canon to the Most Holy Theotokos:

http://web.archive.org/web/20001204003900/http://pages.prodigy.net/frjohnwhiteford/mpthn_canon.htm

Pastoral Letters: This letter: http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-08_2020-03-27.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-07_2020-03-26.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-06_2020-03-21.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-05_2020-03-19.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-04_2020-03-17.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-03_2020-03-17.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-02_2020-03-14.pdf

Diocesan Policy Regarding Public Worship During the Coronavirus Pandemic, Pub 3/24/2020 ns

https://www.chicagodiocese.org/news_200324_1

MANDATORY STAY-AT-HOME ORDER

CITY OF MCKINNEY, TEXAS

EFFECTIVE DATE: THURSDAY, MARCH 26, 2020

https://www.mckinneytexas.org/DocumentCenter/View/22931/COVID-19_StayAtHome_FLYER-1

CITY OF MCKINNEY, TEXAS THIRD REVISED MAYORAL DECLARATION OF LOCAL STATE OF DISASTER DUE TO PUBLIC HEALTH EMERGENCY, 25th day of March, 2020

<https://www.mckinneytexas.org/DocumentCenter/View/22925/Third-Revised-Declaration-of-Local-Disaster-for-Public-Health-Emergency-3-25-2020>